

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ALA_South Africa_2023-24_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

African Leadership Academy (ALA)

Fellowship City

Johannesburg

Fellowship Country

South Africa

Fellowship Start Date

08/17/2023

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/16/2024

What is your fellowship title/role?

Special Projects Fellow / Chief of Staff to the Dean of the Academy

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Building systems for tracking student and staff data and using them to generate insights for decision-making
- Conducting research, planning, modelling, and communications activities related to ALA's next three-year strategic plan
- Streamlining, developing, and enforcing school-related policies and procedures to drive efficiency for the Diploma Program
- Managing special projects and initiatives within the Dean's Office/Diploma Program as they come up

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

At ALA there is a formal three-day orientation program for all new hires. The goal is to provide an overview of ALA and inform new hires of policies and procedures.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

Morning: wake up students in the hall and head to the office
 9 am-12 pm: catch up on emails, join meetings, and complete tasks
 12-1 pm: lunchtime for all ALA community members served in the dining hall
 1-5:30 pm: join meetings and complete tasks
 5:30-6:30 pm: dinner for students and residential faculty served in the dining hall
 9-10 pm: duty once a week, which entails walking around and maintaining presence among students in common spaces

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

- 1) Revamping student support tracker and university transitions tracker. I added functionality and relaunched two trackers that are used by faculty members and the University Guidance team to track and analyze student data.
- 2) Taking part in "Reimagining Faculty", an organizational restructuring project for clarifying job descriptions, solidifying reporting lines, and improving performance management

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

I am part of the Dean's team which includes the Dean of the Academy, the Deputy Dean, the Director of Teaching and Learning, the Director of University Guidance, the Head of Shorts Programs, and the Dean's Office Administrator.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Dean of the Academy.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.**Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.**

- Improve excel skills
- Improve quantitative analysis skills
- Expand network
- Strengthen project management abilities

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).**I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.**

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

The Chief of Staff responsibilities require a very similar skillset to the consulting industry, which is the industry I used to work in before joining ALA.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

ALA purchased my ticket from Amman, Jordan to Johannesburg, South Africa through a travel agency called Indaba Global Travel. I flew on Emirates from Amman to Dubai and then Dubai to Johannesburg. I do not have a return ticket as of now. I don't know how much the flight cost as I didn't book it myself.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Volunteer Visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

South African Embassy in Abu Dhabi, UAE

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Before arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

Visa fees were 2,500 ZAR

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by the organization

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Apply as early as possible

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

No vaccinations were required. I already had the yellow fever vaccine from before.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

Arrival was extremely smooth since ALA provided transport from the airport.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided by the organization. I was given the option to live on campus or off campus. I chose on campus, which entails taking on the Hall Head role for one of the residential halls.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

I live on campus, which is a very safe and family-friendly environment.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I live on campus so I do not commute.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

I do not live in a rural area.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Weather varies throughout the year. Right now, it is summer, so the temperature is warm with occasional rainfall.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

At work, smart casual is most appropriate. Outside of work, any clothing works.

How have you been spending your free time?

I've had little free time so far since I'm applying to graduate school. When I do have free time I like running and reading.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I call my partner every day and I call my family at least three times a week.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

ALA is located in Honeydew, which is a somewhat safe suburb. ALA is gated and there is security 24/7 which makes me feel safe.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

- When I leave ALA I use Uber as opposed to public transport.
- I put all items in my front pockets.
- I try to leave during the daytime.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

There have been moments when I felt unsafe, especially when traveling at night. I also witnessed a pickpocketing experience right in front of me, but thankfully I have not been directly affected by theft or crime.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

ALA usually provides housing either on campus or close to campus in a gated compound called Jackal Creek. Both are safe options for fellows to live in.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I set the following goals for myself: (1) Developing professionally and acquiring new skills, (2) Meeting new people and expanding my network, and (3) Gaining a deeper understanding and appreciation for the local context, perspectives, and challenges. I have made significant strides on all these goals, but the last of the three is something I would like to be more intentional about in the coming months, especially as I wrap up graduate school applications and plan trips around South Africa.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

No major frustrations so far.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Nothing.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I haven't experienced a culture shock. ALA is extremely diverse.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I've been pleasantly surprised by the strong sense of community and camaraderie at ALA, as students and staff collaborate closely, creating a supportive environment for personal and academic growth.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Navigating the balance between building meaningful connections with students at ALA and maintaining professional boundaries has been a challenge. Since I am close in age with the students, it is sometimes difficult to establish boundaries and take on the role of disciplinarian in certain situations.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- Home-cooked food
- Evening and night activities
- Shorter distances between places

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- Weather
- Diversity
- Art scene

How is your stipend being paid?

The stipend is being paid monthly in ZAR to a local account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No I haven't.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$20.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$125.00	\$50.00	\$150.00	\$120.00	\$0.00	\$150.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$200.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	465.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

The orientation was good but I wish it was closer to my start date. I forgot a lot of the information between orientation and my fellowship start date.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

The information provided was sufficient.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

I think the support, materials, and information have been sufficient.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Team-building activities for the cohort.